

MANGROVE Nightmare

A SALTWATER CROCODILE
LAZES IN THE SUN IN
ORISSA'S BHITARKANIKA
NATIONAL PARK

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

Frequent crocodile attacks on villagers in the core area of the Bhitarkanika National Park are the dark lining to the rise in numbers of the endangered reptile



| By Farzand Ahmed |

Be careful. This mangrove forest has a fatal attraction," warned wildlife expert A.K. Patnaik, "if your eyes follow a multi-coloured kingfisher, chances are that you are being followed by a giant, ferocious saltwater crocodile." True. As we were sailing through the turbulent Pathsala, a tributary of the Brahmani, into the Bhitarkanika National Park, a shining red-blue kingfisher flew by. While our eyes chased the rare bird, our motorised boat hit something big and hard. "We just hit a four-metre crocodile. Thank God, it did not attack," said boatman P. Sahu with a smile.

Wildlife experts call this crocodile zone in Baitarani-Brahmani delta of Orissa's Kendrapara district 'the wonderland'. Nestled in the tidal zone of an estuary, it's the second largest compact patch of mangrove

forest in India and one of the best reptilian refuges in the world.

Spread over an area of 672 sq km, Bhitarkanika was notified as a wildlife sanctuary in 1975, and a crocodile core area of 145 sq km with an estimated 1,498 crocodiles was created in 1980. The only way of entering the crocodile kingdom is through the river and it takes two hours by motorised boat from Gupti, 25 km from Rajnagar in Kendrapara. On the banks of the river, huge crocodiles—many of them as long as six metres—are found resting and basking.

The park is surrounded by 34 villages and fishing in the river is a dangerous undertaking. "Early this year, one person was killed while two others were badly mauled by crocodiles," says P. K. Behera, mangrove divisional forest officer (wildlife). Stories of locals being brutally killed

Bhitarkanika (Crocodiles) National Park

Sanctuary Area: 672 Sq Km

Crocodile Core Area: 145 Sq Km

Crocodile Population

1995-94: 511	Adult 10
2000-01: 1,098	Adult 107
2001-02: 1,285	Adult 206
2003-04: 1,358	Adult 220
2004-05: 1,449	Adult 204
2005-06: 1,454	Adult 197
2006-07: 1,482	Adult 224
2007-08: 1,498	Adult 252

Normal size of an adult: 6-7 m

Average weight: 400 Kg